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California brings in new laws changing how you eat forever

September 29, 2026 | New York Post: Web Edition Articles (NY)
Author: Titus Wu | Section: Food & Drink | 1045 Words
OpenURL Link

Dining out in California will forever come with an asterisk.

Under a new law signed Monday, restaurant chains will have to slap a warning – a sugar cube inside a black triangle – on menus next to drinks packing an entire day's recommended amount of added sugar.

The requirement applies to chain restaurants with 20 or more locations and must be in place by Jan. 1, 2029.

Seri, buying drinks in Costco, Los Angeles, on Tuesday supports new sugar warning labels for California. Jonathan Alcorn for CA Post

And at the other end of the food pyramid, California has also signed off on the nation's first "Non-Ultraprocessed Certified" seal, allowing food manufacturers to tout their clean and natural bona fides.

California defines ultra-processed foods as products containing certain additives, including flavors, colors, sweeteners and emulsifiers, or that are high in saturated fat, sodium or added sugar.

The definition was established under a law signed off in 2025 targeting ultra-processed foods served in California's public schools.

Under the new certification program, manufacturers will be able to apply through accredited certification agents to use the new "Non-Ultraprocessed Certified" seal on their products if they meet California's standards.

The program will be overseen by the California Department of Public Health, although manufacturers will not be required to seek certification.

Carter Sakamoto thinks sugar warning labels on sodas are a "joke" Jonathan Alcorn for CA Post

The seal is modeled on the USDA Organic label, which allows shoppers to identify products that meet federal organic standards without having to check lengthy ingredient lists.

Critics have argued the national label doesn't go far enough, as it largely governs how agricultural products are produced and handled rather than guaranteeing that the finished product is healthy or minimally processed.

The federal organic standards include restrictions on pesticides, fertilizers, genetically modified organisms and other production practices, but do not guarantee that a finished product is low in sugar, sodium or saturated fat.

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That means processed products such as cookies, chips and sugary foods can still carry the USDA Organic seal if their ingredients and production methods satisfy federal organic standards.

California's new label instead focuses specifically on whether a finished food meets the state's standards for avoiding ultra-processing.

Health experts praised California's new law, noting concerns over the health effects of diets high in ultra-processed foods.

"Ultra processed foods are fueling a surge in chronic conditions among children, obesity, type two diabetes, and even mental health challenges like anxiety and depression," said pediatrician Ravinder Khaira, speaking on behalf of the American Academy of Pediatrics.

California Gov. Gavin Newsom announces his signature on legislation advancing California's holistic healthcare strategy to address ultra-processed foods, high-sugar content, and tobacco. Governor Gavin Newsom

"These aren't distant threats. They're showing up in our exam rooms every day."

However, some critics have questioned whether the label could confuse consumers if other states adopt their own definitions and standards for ultra-processed foods.

While the new California label is not mandatory, Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, who authored the law, said it will empower consumers looking for healthier options.

"While Washington D.C. is paralyzed by inaction, Republicans and Democrats in California are joining forces to empower consumers to avoid harmful ultra-processed foods," he said.

A woman shops for drinks and snacks in a small convenience store in Los Angeles, California, Friday, March 31, 2023. Getty Images

"Parents shouldn't need a Ph.D. in chemistry to understand what they're feeding their kids."

However, reaction to the new mandatory sugar warning law was more divided, with restaurants hitting out at yet another burden for an industry that's seen mass job losses and store closures since the introduction of California's $20 per hour minimum wage for fast food workers.

The California Restaurant Association said the sugar law was just another burden on an industry struggling in a regulation-heavy state.

Large restaurant chains are already required under law to provide calorie information on both food and drinks, the association said.

View this post on Instagram A Jack in the Box fast food restaurant outdoor drive-thru menu is pictured on Monday, May 25, 2026, in Davis, California. Getty Images

"SB 869 is another example of California making small business owners comply with yet another law that is duplicative," the California Restaurant Association said in a statement.

Carter Sakamoto, who was buying a soda at Costco on Tuesday, agreed with the restaurant industry and described the new sugar warning labels as "stupid."

"I think that as Californians, we have a lot of bigger problems than sugary sodas. It's a waste of taxpayers' time."

But health advocates praised the law as a needed transparency measure that will allow consumers to know what they're actually drinking.

"A single beverage may not seem like much, but over time, it can significantly impact someone's health trajectory," Christine Harabedian, a lobbyist for the American Diabetes Association, said.

"Studies show that adding just one 12-ounce sugary drink daily increases the risk of developing type two diabetes by 26%."

Supporters have pointed to research by the University of California, Davis showing that warning labels on restaurant menus steer diners away from sugary drinks.

A customer fills a Coca-Cola cup with Coke at a soda fountain at a food court outside a Costco Wholesale warehouse store in Hawthorne, California, Wednesday, August 27, 2025. AFP via Getty Images

Another shopper, Seri, said the sugar warning law had been "a long time coming."

"As humans, we should know what we're putting into our bodies, especially foods with high sugar, like soda, that we consume every day," she said.

"Whether you choose to ignore the sign is up to you, but I fully support knowing how much sugar I'm consuming."

Example sugar warning labels used by UC Davis in its reasearch. UC Davis Example sugar warning labels used by UC Davis in its reasearch.

Gov. Gavin Newsom framed the two laws as a health care solution.

"We should be about healthcare, not sick-care, recognizing that preventing illnesses is far preferable to finding — and affording — treatments," Newsom said in a Monday statement.

"California has never been afraid to challenge the status quo, and we'll keep innovating, trying new things, and clearing the way for the rest of the country to follow."

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Wu, T. (2026, September 29). California brings in new laws changing how you eat forever*New York Post: Web Edition Articles (NY)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1AAF2A87974922C8.